PUBLIC SPEAKING · LESSON 1 OF 1

Public Speaking Complete Guide: Confidence, Structure, Storytelling, Delivery, Slides, Meetings, Interviews and Video

A practical guide to speaking with confidence at work and on stage. Manage nerves, structure any talk with proven frameworks, tell stories with data, design clear slides, master voice, pace and body language, handle Q&A and tough questions, speak in meetings, interviews and stand-ups, present on video and in hybrid rooms, and practise with AI tools, with a 30-day plan and a capstone talk.

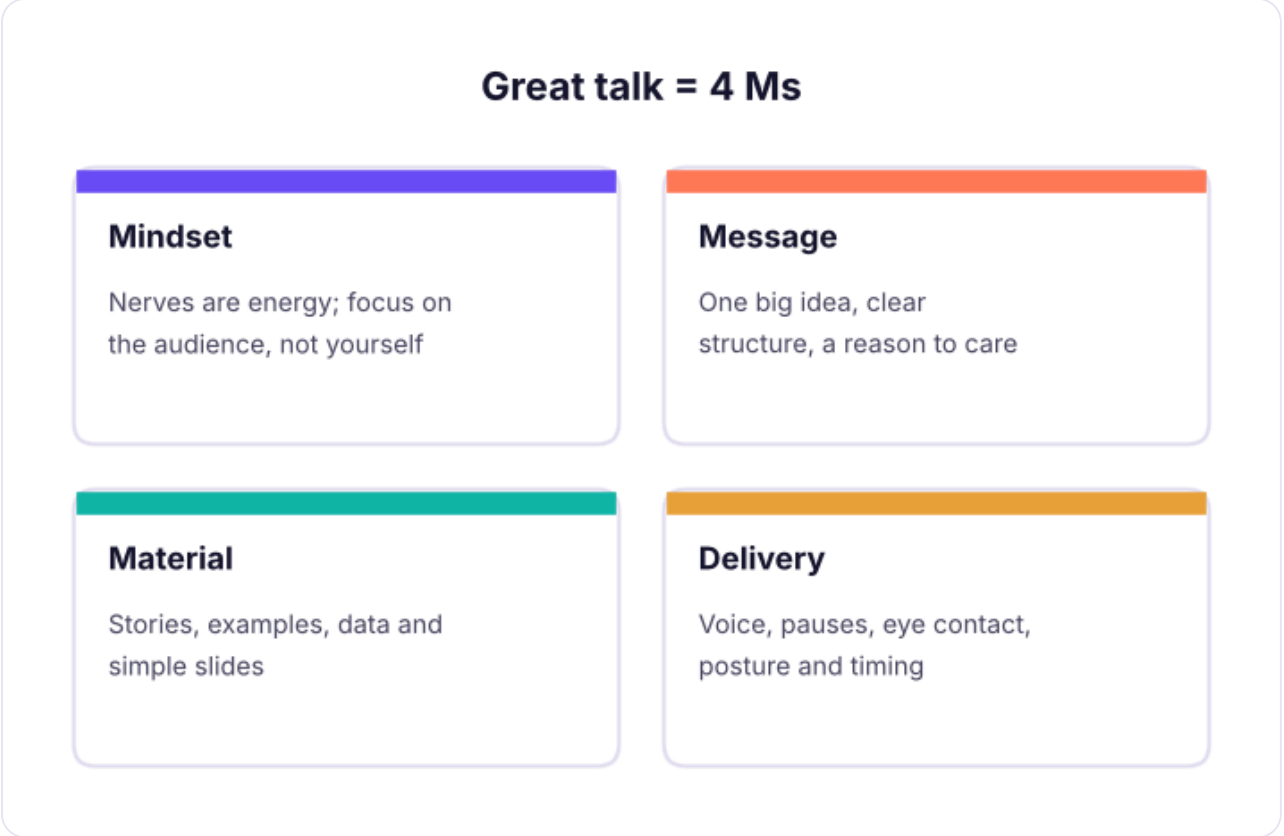
✦ 2026 | Beginner to Advanced | ⏱ 180 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Manage speaking anxiety with preparation, breathing and reframing techniques
- Structure talks and answers with frameworks such as PREP, STAR, What-So What-Now What and the pyramid principle
- Tell stories and present data so audiences remember and act
- Deliver with a clear voice, purposeful pauses, eye contact and confident body language, in person and on video
- Handle Q&A, difficult questions and high-stakes moments like interviews and leadership updates

Why speaking skills decide careers

Product managers present roadmaps, analysts explain numbers, engineers demo work, and every interview is a speaking test. People who communicate clearly get trusted with bigger problems. The good news: speaking is a skill, not a talent, and it improves quickly with structure and practice.



The four parts of a great talk.

Managing nerves

Technique	How
Prepare the first 60 seconds word-perfect	The opening is when nerves peak; a rehearsed start carries you
Box breathing	Breathe in 4 s, hold 4 s, out 4 s, hold 4 s; repeat four times before you speak
Reframe	"I'm excited" instead of "I'm nervous": the body feels the same
Audience focus	Ask "what do they need?" instead of "how do I look?"
Rehearse aloud	Three full out-loud rehearsals beat ten silent read-throughs
Arrive early	Test the room, mic, screen share and clicker; meet a few people first
Friendly faces	Speak to a few engaged people in different parts of the room

Structure: frameworks that always work

Framework	Use for	Shape
PREP	Opinions, quick answers in meetings	Point → Reason → Example → Point
STAR	Interview stories	Situation → Task → Action → Result (with numbers)
What? So what? Now what?	Updates and reviews	Facts → why they matter → next steps
Problem → Solution → Benefit	Pitches and proposals	Pain → your idea → value
Pyramid principle	Leadership updates, written and spoken	Answer first → 3 supporting points → details
Past → Present → Future	Strategy and roadmap talks	Where we were → where we are → where we're going

Python

```
def prep(point, reason, example):
    return f"My view: {point}\nWhy: {reason}\nFor example: {example}\nSo: {point}"
print(prep("we should launch the referral feature before Diwali",
           "festive weeks bring 40% of our yearly new users, and referrals convert twice as well as ads",
           "last year's 'invite a friend' test lifted sign-ups by 18% in two weeks"))
```

OUTPUT

```
My view: we should launch the referral feature before Diwali
Why: festive weeks bring 40% of our yearly new users, and referrals convert twice as well as ads
For example: last year's 'invite a friend' test lifted sign-ups by 18% in two weeks
So: we should launch the referral feature before Diwali
```

Openings that grab attention: a surprising number, a short story, a question to the room, a bold claim, or a problem the audience feels. Closings that stick: repeat the one big idea, give a clear call to action, and end on a strong line rather than "that's all, thank you".

Storytelling

A simple story arc: **context** (who, where) → **conflict** (what went wrong or was at stake) → **turning point** (what you did or learned) → **resolution** (result, with numbers) → **lesson** (why it matters to

them).

Tips: one main character, concrete details ("a Tuesday night, 2 am, the payment dashboard went red"), real dialogue, and a lesson tied to the audience's goal.

Presenting data

- Lead with the **insight**, not the chart: "Repeat orders fell 12% after the price change."
- One message per slide; make the title the takeaway sentence.
- Highlight the one bar or line that matters; grey out the rest.
- Translate numbers into meaning: "₹2.4 crore a year, about the cost of 10 engineers."
- Round sensibly and compare to something familiar.

Python

```python
before, after, customers, aov = 0.38, 0.33, 120_000, 1800
lost_orders = (before - after) * customers
print(f"Repeat rate {before:.0%} → {after:.0%}: about {lost_orders:,.0f} fewer repeat orders, ≈ ₹{lost_orders * aov / 1e7:.2f} crore in revenue")
```

OUTPUT

```
Repeat rate 38% → 33%: about 6,000 fewer repeat orders, ≈ ₹1.08 crore in revenue
```

Slides that help, not hurt

Do	Avoid
Headline that states the takeaway	Titles like "Q3 data"
One idea per slide, big visuals	Walls of text you then read aloud
24pt+ text, high contrast	Tiny tables, 8 colours per chart
Speaker notes for you	Notes on the slide for the audience
A backup appendix for detail	Putting every detail in the main flow

Tools: Google Slides, PowerPoint (Designer and Copilot), Canva, Pitch, Gamma; use AI for a first draft, then cut ruthlessly.

Delivery: voice and body

Element	Practice
Pace	About 130–150 words per minute; slow down for key points
Pauses	Pause 2 seconds after an important line and before answering questions
Volume and variety	Project to the back row; vary pitch to avoid a monotone
Fillers	Replace "um", "basically", "like" with a silent pause
Eye contact	One thought per person, 3–5 seconds each
Posture and hands	Feet grounded, open gestures between waist and shoulders
Movement	Move with purpose (to a new point), then stand still

Python

```
script_words, minutes = 1150, 8
wpm = script_words / minutes
print(f"{wpm:.0f} words per minute →", "good pace" if 120 ⩽ wpm ⩽ 160 else "too fast:
cut content or slow down" if wpm > 160 else "a little slow: tighten the script")
```

OUTPUT

```
144 words per minute → good pace
```

Q&A and difficult questions

1. **Listen fully**, pause, and repeat or rephrase the question for the room.
2. **Answer briefly** (PREP), then check: "Does that answer it?"
3. **Don't know?** Say so, and commit to follow up by a date.
4. **Hostile question?** Acknowledge the concern, bridge to facts, stay calm and specific.
5. **Off-topic or long questions?** Offer to take it offline.
6. **Seed the first question** or prepare an "a question I often get is..." if the room is quiet.

Speaking at work

Situation	Approach
Stand-up	Yesterday / today / blockers in under 60 seconds
Leadership update	Bottom line first, then 3 points, risks and the decision you need
Product demo	Start with the user problem, show the "aha" moment early, keep a backup video
Disagreeing in a meeting	"I see it differently because...", then data and a proposal
Interviews	STAR stories with numbers; pause to think; structure out loud
Client calls	Agenda upfront, check understanding, summarise next steps in writing

Video, online and hybrid

- Camera at eye level, face lit from the front, clean background, a decent USB or lavalier mic.
- Look at the camera for key points; keep slides simple for small screens.
- Turn on captions; share only the window you need; close notifications.
- For hybrid rooms, involve remote people first in Q&A and repeat in-room questions.
- For recorded content (YouTube, LinkedIn), script the hook and first line, then speak conversationally.

Practise with AI

Tool	Use
PowerPoint Speaker Coach / Presenter Coach	Feedback on pace, fillers and reading slides
Yoodli	AI speech coaching on recordings and mock interviews
Claude / ChatGPT voice mode	Rehearse Q&A: ask it to play a sceptical stakeholder or interviewer
Your phone camera	Record, watch once with sound off (body) and once without video (voice)
Toastmasters clubs	Regular practice with feedback in most Indian cities and online

A 30-day plan

Python

```
plan = {"Week 1": "Record a 2-minute self-introduction daily; remove one filler habit",
        "Week 2": "Use PREP for every opinion in meetings; tell one story a day to a
friend",
        "Week 3": "Build a 5-minute talk with the pyramid principle and 6 slides; rehearse
3 times",
        "Week 4": "Deliver it to a small group or a Toastmasters club; collect feedback;
give it again"}
for w, t in plan.items(): print(f"{w}: {t}")
```

OUTPUT

```
Week 1: Record a 2-minute self-introduction daily; remove one filler habit
Week 2: Use PREP for every opinion in meetings; tell one story a day to a friend
Week 3: Build a 5-minute talk with the pyramid principle and 6 slides; rehearse 3
times
Week 4: Deliver it to a small group or a Toastmasters club; collect feedback; give it
again
```

Capstone: a 7-minute talk

Choose a topic from your work ("How we cut checkout drop-off by 15%"): opening hook, one big idea, three points with a story and one data slide, a clear call to action, rehearsed three times with a timer, recorded, reviewed against the delivery table, and delivered to an audience with Q&A.

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Manage nerves with preparation, breathing, reframing and audience focus.
- Structure every talk or answer: PREP, STAR, pyramid principle, What-So what-Now what.
- Stories and clear data make messages memorable; slides should support, not replace, you.
- Delivery is pace, pauses, voice, eye contact and posture; practise aloud and on video.
- Handle Q&A calmly: listen, rephrase, answer briefly, follow up when you don't know.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Which framework suits a quick opinion in a meeting?

- **A** PREP: Point, Reason, Example, Point
- **B** STAR
- **C** SWOT
- **D** RICE

Answer: A. STAR is for interview stories.

2. What should a slide title say?

- **A** The takeaway, as a sentence
- **B** Just the topic, like "Q3 data"
- **C** Nothing
- **D** The company name

Answer: A. Titles carry the message.

3. What is a good replacement for filler words like "um"?

- **A** A short silent pause
- **B** Speaking faster
- **C** Saying "basically"
- **D** Reading the slide

Answer: A. Pauses sound confident.

4. Someone asks a question you cannot answer. What do you do?

A Say you don't know and commit to follow up by a specific time

B Make up an answer

C Ignore it

D Change the subject

Answer: A. Credibility beats bluffing.

5. Which order fits a leadership update?

A Bottom line first, then supporting points, risks and the decision needed

B A long background first

C All details on every slide

D Questions before context

Answer: A. The pyramid principle.

6. About what speaking pace is comfortable for most audiences?

A About 130-150 words per minute

B 250 words per minute

C 60 words per minute

D It does not matter

Answer: A. Slow down for key points.

EXERCISE **Practice**

Write a 2-minute "tell me about yourself" using Past → Present → Future and one STAR story with a number. Record it, count your words per minute and filler words, then re-record with three improvements.

Show solution (worked answer)

A strong answer: one line on background, current role and a quantified achievement (STAR), why the next role fits, under 2 minutes at 130–150 wpm, with pauses replacing fillers and eye contact with the camera.

INTERVIEW CORNER **Questions you may be asked**

Q: Tell me about yourself. Past (relevant background) → present (current role and one quantified win) → future (why this role), in under two minutes.

Q: Describe a time you had to present to senior leaders. STAR: the situation and stakes, how you structured the message answer-first, how you handled questions, and the decision or result.

Q: How do you explain a technical idea to a non-technical audience? Start with why it matters to them, use an analogy, avoid jargon, show one example, and check understanding.

Q: How do you handle disagreement in a meeting? Acknowledge the other view, explain your reasoning with data, propose a way to test or decide, and agree next steps.

Q: How do you prepare for an important presentation? Know the audience and the decision needed, build an answer-first storyline, design simple slides, rehearse aloud with a timer, prepare likely questions and test the setup.

Learn more

- Toastmasters International
- TED Masterclass and TED talks on speaking
- Microsoft Speaker Coach
- Yoodli AI speech coach

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.